Frame Semantics in Bible Study

Based on Genesis Marks the Spot, episode 121 -
Devil in the Details: Rest, Relief, and Frame Semantics

What is Frame Semantics and Why Does It Matter for Bible Study?

Frame semantics is the idea that words don't exist in isolation—they evoke entire **conceptual frames** made up of roles, relationships, and background knowledge. When we read Scripture, words like "rest," "sacrifice," or "Satan" carry layers of meaning shaped by ancient cultural, theological, and narrative contexts. A frame semantic approach helps us see the richness and interconnectedness of biblical language, revealing how meaning is found not just in the word itself, but in the frame it activates. This can also help us see the Bible in its ancient light versus how we currently understand terms and ideas. It's a powerful tool for studying the Bible on its own terms—contextually, relationally, and holistically.

Key Terms Overview

- **Frame Semantics**: A way of understanding meaning by looking at the *conceptual scenes* or *frames* that words evoke.
- **Lexical Unit**: A specific word or phrase that is used *in a specific context* (e.g., "relief" in Genesis 5:29) that activates a frame.
- **Frame**: The mental structure or storyline behind a word—like a "container" that holds the frame elements or a "scene" that gives the word its meaning.
- **Frame Elements**: The key roles or parts of that frame—people, actions, settings, goals—that the word assumes (e.g., giver of relief, recipient, burden, place of rest).
- **Semantic Roles**: Broad *functional roles* that participants play within an event (e.g., agent, experiencer, theme); these describe "who is doing what to/with whom."

Today, we often use truth conditional semantics to determine meaning and truth.

The contrast between truth conditionals and frames:

Truth-conditional semantics asks what must be true for a statement to be accurate; **frame semantics** asks what background structures must be in place for a word to be meaningful.

Step-by-Step Guide: How to Use Frame Semantics

An example from Genesis 5:29

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*“And he called his name Noah, saying, 'This one will give us **relief** from our work and from the toil of our hands, from the ground which YHWH has cursed.”* (Genesis 5:29, my translation)

1. **Identify the lexical unit (word or phrase in context/actual use):**
→ **“Relief”** (Hebrew: *naḥam*)
The use suggests more than physical rest—implying change, an emotional or existential relief.

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2. **Ask: What kind of scene or frame is this word evoking?**
→ A **Toil-and-Relief Frame** that overlaps with the **Divine Rest Frame**: a world marked by cursed ground and painful labor, *paired with* a longing for comfort, renewal, and a return to God’s intended order.

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3. **Name or describe the frame:**

> A frame involving burden, divine curse, human suffering, and hope for someone to reverse or alleviate that burden.

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4. **Identify the frame elements (roles in the scene):**

Frame Element	Textual Example
Burden	Toil, cursed ground
Experiencer	Humanity (those doing the toil)
Giver of relief	Noah (his name means “rest”)
Source of burden	God’s curse on the ground
Result (hoped for)	Comfort, ease, perhaps reversal

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5. **Observe how the frame shapes meaning:**
→ This isn’t “relief” as a nap or vacation or even a temporary reprieve. It’s **prophetic hope for reversal of the curse**—a theological frame of burden, redemption, and divine intervention that anticipates or participates in the broader **Divine Rest Frame**, where God restores creation through rest, presence, and covenant.

Before You Begin: Tips for Frame-Based Interpretation

What to Consider When Analyzing a Frame

1. **Literary Context Matters**
Don't isolate the verse—look at what comes before and after. How does this passage build on or contrast with the surrounding material?

2. **Cultural and Theological Memory**
Ask what background stories or categories the author assumes the reader knows—like covenant, temple, exile, divine council, etc. What kind of a world do they live in?

3. **Avoid Anachronism**
Keep the meaning grounded in the world of the text. Don't import modern definitions or ideas (e.g., "Satan" as a red devil, or "rest" as a lazy afternoon playing video games).

4. **You Don't Have to Name the Frame Right Away**
Sometimes you'll sense a "scene" before you have a label for it. Describe the relationships and roles first—then try to name the frame!

5. **Frame Elements Are Roles and States, Not Just People and Things**
A "role" might be a person, object, or even an abstract idea—like "burden," "place of presence," or "symbol of authority."

Example Frames Often Invoked in Scripture

- **Creation Frame** – disorder → order → rest
- **Divine Council Frame** – heavenly courtroom, decision-making
- **Covenant Frame** – relationship, promise, identity
- **Exodus Frame** – oppression, deliverance, land
- **Temple Frame** – sacred space, presence, worship

Can you think of other frames that Scripture presents?

What are some frames you tend to assume when reading Scripture?

Where might our modern assumptions clash with the frames the biblical authors were activating?

How might recognizing a frame help us better understand the *purpose* and *meaning* behind a word or passage? Does this affect *interpretation?*

Frame Semantics Guided Practice 1

Use the steps below to begin interpreting this verse using frame semantics.
Note: Remember to draw on broader contextual clues the author appears to be invoking or building upon—such as cultural, theological, or narrative frames the passage echoes or participates in. Do not include anachronistic information or modern assumptions.

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*"And there was a day when came the sons of God to present themselves before YHWH, and came also **the satan** among them."* (Job 1:6, my translation)

1. **Lexical Unit (word in context): →**

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2. **What kind of scene or frame is being evoked? →**

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3. **Name or describe the frame: →**

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4. **Identify the frame elements (adding anything you feel is relevant):**

Frame Element	Example from Passage
Authority Figure	
Council Members	
Accuser / Prosecutor	
Setting / Context	
Purpose of Gathering	

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5. **How does the frame shape the meaning of the passage? →**

Frame Semantics Guided Practice 2

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*“And the great dragon was thrown down—the serpent of old, the one called Devil and **the Satan**, the one deceiving the whole inhabited world—he was thrown down to the earth, and his angels were thrown down with him."* (Revelation 12:9, my translation)

1. **Lexical Unit (word in context): →**

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2. **What kind of scene or frame is being evoked? →**

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3. **Name or describe the frame: →**

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4. **Identify the frame elements (adding anything you feel is relevant):**

Frame Element	Example from Passage
Cosmic Opponent	
Allies / Army	
Divine Warrior / Judge	
Victims of Deception	
Scope of Conflict	
Ultimate Outcome / Judgment	

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5. **How does the frame shape the meaning of the passage? →**

Frame Semantics Guided Practice, Continued: Contrasting Frames for Satan

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Use the questions below to reflect on how frame semantics helps uncover theological meaning in Scripture:

1. How does the role of “the satan” in Job differ from later uses of “Satan” as the enemy of God?

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2. What clues in the text (or surrounding context) help you determine which frame is being activated?

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3. How does the frame in Revelation shape your understanding of evil, conflict, and redemption?

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4. In what ways does the Job frame challenge or expand modern assumptions about Satan?

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5. How can paying attention to frames change the way we read other theological terms (like son, rest, or sacrifice)?

Frame Semantics Example - Divine Rest Frame

from episode 121 of Genesis Marks the Spot

What Is the Divine Rest Frame?

A theological frame in which God brings the created order from toil, curse, and chaos into rest, presence, and restoration.

Lexical Units That Activate This Frame

- Rest (*nuach*, *anapausis*)
- Relief (*revach*, *yeshuah*)
- Sabbath (*shabbat*)
- Inheritance
- Land (as place of rest)
- Dwelling / Tabernacle / Temple
- Shalom

Core Frame Elements

Frame Element	Example from Passage
Divine Agent / Giver	God, YHWH, Jesus
Recipients	Israel, humanity, the weary, the land itself
Burden / Toil	Labor, slavery, exile, sin, death
Relief / Rest	Physical rest, spiritual renewal, covenant fulfillment
Time	7th day, Sabbath, Jubilee, Messianic age
Place	Garden, Promised land, tabernacle, temple, New Jerusalem
Sign / Symbol	Sabbath, divine presence, temple, Body of Christ
Outcome	Restoration, presence, worship, peace, new creation

Theological Function

The **Divine Rest Frame** reveals how rest is not simply cessation of work, but the *goal of creation*, the *center of covenant life*, and the *promise of final restoration*. It connects creation, redemption, and eschatology into a single theological vision of divine order and peace.

Keep Going – Applying Frame Semantics in Your Study

Now that you've explored what frame semantics is and how it works in Scripture, here are some ways to keep learning and applying this tool:

📚 Practice On Your Own

- Choose a familiar passage and focus on one key word. Ask: *What frame is being activated here?*
- Use the blank template in this packet to test out your observations.
- Create multiple frames for the same word in different passages and see what nuance this might open up for interpretation and understanding.

🔍 Words to Explore

Try analyzing biblical terms like:

- Sacrifice
- Glory
- Inheritance
- Son
- Righteousness
- Exile
- Redeem
- Covenant

🧠 Reflect and Discuss

- What frames do you bring into Scripture from your own cultural context?
- How does identifying a frame shift your interpretation of a passage?
- Go beyond single frames and nest frames within each other, or contrast them to see what different authors were trying to say.

🎙️ Want More?

This material is featured in the *Genesis Marks the Spot* episode:
Devil in the Details: Rest, Relief, and Frame Semantics - Episode 121
You can find it here: www.genesismarksthespot.com/121

👥 Group or Classroom Use

- Use a frame-based approach for group Bible study or discussion.
- Invite learners to compare their findings and reflect together.

Frame semantics doesn't *replace* traditional study—it *enhances* it by helping us read words as the original authors and audiences likely understood them: embedded in meaningful, living story-worlds.

Frame Semantics Blank Template

Passage:

1. **Lexical Unit (word in context): →**

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2. **What kind of scene or frame is being evoked? →**

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3. **Name or describe the frame: →**

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4. **Identify the frame elements (adding anything you feel is relevant):**

Frame Element	Example from Passage

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5. **How does the frame shape the meaning of the passage? →**